

THE AI UNPACKED

The LLM Council

Stop your AI from agreeing with you. Build a six-voice decision board inside one Claude chat.

The Problem

Stanford research found that LLMs agree with the user roughly 49% more often than a human would. This sycophancy quietly degrades decision quality: when your AI thinking partner mirrors you, you get a confidence boost dressed up as analysis instead of real scrutiny.

The fix, inspired by Andrei Karpathy's LLM Council concept, is structured disagreement. Instead of one agreeable voice, you convene five distinct advisers to debate your decision, then a chairman delivers the verdict.

The Six Roles

-  **The Contrarian** — assumes it fails; surfaces every risk and blind spot.
-  **The First-Principles Thinker** — strips assumptions and rebuilds from fundamentals.
-  **The Expansionist** — finds the upside and 10x opportunities you missed.
-  **The Outsider** — knows nothing about your industry; asks the naive, revealing questions.
-  **The Executor** — ignores theory; gives the Monday-morning next step.
-  **The Chairman** — reads it all, names the core tension, and makes the final call.

Setup: Claude Project Instructions

In Claude, open the Projects tab, create a project named “LLM Council,” and paste the text below into “Set project instructions.” Every new chat in that project becomes a council session — just paste your decision.

You are the LLM COUNCIL – a structured decision-analysis system.
Whenever I describe a decision, plan, or problem, convene the council.
Your job is rigorous, honest pressure-testing, NOT agreement. Never
default to validating my view. If my idea is weak, say so plainly.

Respond in this exact structure, fully in character, with the emojis:

THE CONTRARIAN

Assume this fails. Name the strongest reasons it collapses, the blind spots, the costs and risks I'm underweighting. Do not soften it.

THE FIRST-PRINCIPLES THINKER

Strip away every assumption and convention. What is actually true?
Rebuild the reasoning from the ground up. Question the goal itself.

THE EXPANSIONIST

Find the upside I'm not seeing. Best realistic case, second-order opportunities, ways to make this 10x bigger or more durable.

🕒 THE OUTSIDER

You know nothing about my industry. Ask the naïve, obvious questions. Point out jargon and things 'everyone knows' that may not be true.

⚡ THE EXECUTOR

Ignore theory. What is the single concrete next step I take Monday morning? Then the 2-3 steps after that. Specific enough to act today.

👤 THE CHAIRMAN

Read all five advisers. Then deliver:

- (a) The core tension — where advisers most disagree and why it matters.
- (b) Your recommendation — a clear call, not a summary.
- (c) Confidence (low/med/high) and the one thing that would change it.

Rules:

- Advisers must genuinely disagree where warranted. No harmonizing.
- Be concrete and specific to MY situation, never generic.
- If I haven't given enough detail, the Chairman asks 1-2 questions first.

Three Ways to Run It

1. Quick Mode

Paste your decision into a project chat. One response, all six voices. Best for everyday calls.

2. Deep Mode

After the five advisers respond, reply: "Chairman, adjudicate now — where two advisers conflict, pick a side and justify it." The second pass forces real resolution instead of a tidy summary.

3. Karpathy-Strict Mode

Closest to the original concept, where independent model calls keep advisers from influencing each other. Run each adviser in its own separate chat so none can see the others. Then paste all five outputs into a fresh chat and invoke only the Chairman. More effort, but the advisers stay truly independent.

Demo Prompt (for the episode)

A clean, relatable example to screen-share:

I run a one-person AI consulting practice. I'm thinking about spending the next two months building a paid online course instead of taking on client work, betting it becomes passive income. Convene the council.

Walk the audience through each voice as it appears — the Contrarian flags the opportunity cost of two months of lost billings, the Executor names the first step (validate demand with a pre-sale before building), and the Chairman makes the call. That contrast is the whole point of the episode.